

Steam Early Access

Good news for you game lovers as Steam Early Access will allow for easy public game testing with officially sanctioned peeks. <http://dgit.in/Yqu1st>



Twitter turns seven

Twitter completed seven years last month. After these many years, Twitter has about 200 million active users who pump out 400 million tweets a day



Not the best idea of all time. Yet.

every time you want to get somewhere (or, you know, kill you if you were thinking about 'The Prestige' just before you used the Transporter). On a related note, we probably wouldn't mind it that much – more crew on deck, right?

The Tractor Beam

Another significant part of Star Trek were the relatively underrated tractor beams. Truth be told, they would be anything but, once we actually start using them in real life, because that is about the highest degree of Star Trek action most of us are going to get in our lives – and not only because they can be deceptively practical in day-to-day life. Of course, practicality is not what true sci-fi fans look for, but such is the tragedy of life that we must rationalise the hand we've dealt with. Anyway, as we know, tractor beams are basically streams of laser that would trigger motions in the object in focus. And this concept has now made its way into the real world. It all begins with something called a 'Bessel Beam' (two of them, actually). This kind of beam has the extraordinary property of being composed of concentric circles of EM-waves, rather than the plain old, boring straight shots. This lends a very interesting property to the waves – they are

non diffractive, i.e., they do not spread out like usual light. Also, they are 'self healing', meaning that if they encounter a relatively small obstruction in their path, they would simply reform the disturbance after crossing the obstructing object. It is this self-healing property that, as an interesting side-effect, causes the beam to push the object back, towards the source by the application of energy from the beam. This is, by all means, an honest-to-goodness implementation of the famed Star Trek beam. The only downer is that this only works for microscopic particles yet, and if scaled exactly as-is for larger applications, it would probably destroy the object in question before moving its debris. That would, by the way, still be a 10 on the awesomeness scale.

Loads of cool goodies

There are, of course many relatively small tid-bits of the show which were useful but not exactly as glorified as the above examples. One of them might be the Tricoder (although it is, admittedly, pretty famous). So what Mr. Peter Jansen has gone on to do is build his own version of the tricoder. The project had the humble beginnings of a glorified multi-meter, but is now growing to become closer to its fantasy world counterpart, in that it is actually something that you can see Spock holding in his hands and figuring out insane amounts of detail about uncharted territories. If we remember correctly, there was also a medical Tricoder, and of course, if it was there then someone somewhere has to have been working a real life version all this time. Sure enough, there has been a lot of work, and the major breakthrough has been made by a team at Purdue University, who claim to have created a handheld sensing system its creators say could be used for testing foods for dangerous bacterial

contaminants. Close enough. For now, that is. If we were to look closely, and indeed we should, we realize that there are actually an unreal number of Star Trek visions that have (or have been made to) come to life. None more surprising than the concept of personal computers themselves. Of course, you might say that it was relatively obvious – but how about this, they also predicted the advent of tablets! We can also safely count things a GPS (they did do an awful lot of remote sensing on the crew, remember?), biometric safety precautions, possibly the mobile phone (thinking of the communicator here), and, wait for it, even wireless blue-tooth earpieces! Even today, a man walking

Which Star Trek are we talking about?

Although most of these technologies are the common denominators of even the non-Star-Trek-but-Sci-Fi shows, if you ask us, the Original Series trumps the Next Generation by so, so much that it did not even occur to us to mention this before somebody pointed out that it might be a doubt to the uninitiated.

down the street with a wireless headset on, seems like someone who knows his way around the world. We cannot even begin to imagine the awe which they would have created around the fantastic crew flying around space in awesome ships wearing those God-awful but surprisingly respect/fear/something-of-the-kind inducing devices.

People swoon over how visionary and accurate the producers of the show turned out to be, because so many of its components are starting to come alive in one form or the other. Credit where it's due, of course, but we belong to a slightly different (opposite, so to speak) school thought. Right about now is the time that the first proper generation that grew up with the show is 'coming-of-age' in a professional sense, and that they are consciously trying to make their childhood dreams come true. It is, of course, widely believed that Star Trek has been a great recruiter for advanced studies in Physics, Astronomy, Mechanics and anything else that can be vaguely related to the franchise. A self-fulfilling prophecy, if there ever was one. Well played, science, well played. ■



The common denominator to every sci-fi story, ever.